opportunity cost in obtaining valuable skills. As one sarcastic letter to a newspaper editor in 1973 pointed out:[54]

> There is much talk these days about the ‘Sons of the Soil’ . . . Only those born in the alluvial soil can work in the alluvian region. They may call themselves ‘alluvians’ . . . People may be given identity cards with the name of the soil clearly printed on it. To solve the problems of babies born in the air (planes), they should be employed as pilots and air hostesses. Nobody except the sons and daughters of the air should get these air jobs. They should be allowed to stay on earth in a non-classified soil region when they are off-duty.

Cultural differences in India that spark nativism and discrimination manifest from various identities, usually language and religion, but increasingly, race. In recent decades, people from the eight states of the Northeast have been moving to major metropolitan centres such as Delhi, Bengaluru and Mumbai for education and jobs in the services sector where their English-speaking skills are highly valued. In those cities, they face discrimination not because of fears of a demographic somersault but due to racial differences as many have Mongoloid features.[55] In one outrageous episode in Bengaluru in 2012, north-easterners began to flee the city because of rumours about revenge attacks by Muslims protesting Muslims being killed in distant Burma. Women from the Northeast, many who work in the beauty and care sector, and have a relatively higher degree of autonomy, are stereotyped by the locals as being ‘easy’ or pliable for sexual favours. As a result, obtaining rental accommodation can be a nightmarish ordeal for them. The word ‘chinki’, meaning Chinese, was earlier used as a derogatory word but using it now is a punishable offence. However, Indian-Chinese restaurants do staff a large number of people from the Northeast, a phenomenon that has little logic but accords well with the idea that Indian consumers are supposed to assume that people with Mongoloid features ought to serve in Chinese restaurants. Racial tensions against migrants are also played out these days against Africans, many of whom come to India for higher education. Today’s stereotype of the African in India is that of a drug dealer, far removed from the medieval era when Habshi freed-slaves were part of the Deccan nobility and noted for their integrity.